

Place (Distribution) Playbook

How fashion brands choose where to sell, through which channels, and when to expand.

What this playbook gives you

- A practical definition of **Place** in marketing (distribution), not theory.
- A channel map: **DTC vs Wholesale vs Retail** + marketplaces, pop-ups, and partners.
- When to use each channel + pros/cons and the hidden costs founders miss.
- Online vs physical comparison + a stage-based expansion plan.
- Checklists and KPIs so you pick channels based on numbers, not vibes.

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1. What “Place” really means

In the 4Ps, **Place** is the **distribution system**: where the customer can discover, evaluate, buy, receive, and return your product. For fashion, Place also shapes your brand. The same hoodie feels different when it’s bought from a premium website, a kiosk, or a discount marketplace.

Place controls...	Examples (fashion)
Availability	Do people find your size, color, and best sellers when they want them?
Speed	Same-day delivery vs 5-day shipping; in-store pickup; returns turnaround.
Experience	Packaging, unboxing, styling help, store service, checkout friction.
Trust	Payment options, reviews, cash-on-delivery (if used), return policy clarity.
Margin	Fees, discounts, wholesale pricing, commissions, rent, staff costs.

Ruthless truth

- A “new channel” is not growth by default. It’s a **new set of costs**, operational complexity, and customer expectations.
- If your **product, price, and offer** are weak, Place only spreads the weakness faster.
- Expand channels only when your current channel has a proven, repeatable sales engine.

2. Channel map: your distribution options

Think of Place as a set of routes from your brand to the customer. You can control the route (DTC), share control (retail partners), or give up control for volume (wholesale / marketplaces).

Route	What it is	Who owns the customer?	Typical margin outcome
DTC (Direct-to-Consumer)	You sell directly: website, social, WhatsApp, pop-up.	You own it	Highest potential margin
Retail (your own store)	You run the store experience.	You own it	High margin, high fixed cost
Retail partners	Stores sell your brand.	Shared / store owns it	Medium margin, medium complexity
Wholesale	You sell units to a buyer who resells.	Buyer owns it	Lower margin, volume + cashflow tradeoffs
Marketplaces	Platform brings traffic (Jumia, Amazon, etc.).	Platform owns it	Lower margin, high dependency

Simple decision rule

- **Need control + brand + data?** Start DTC.
- **Need fast distribution but you can handle lower margins?** Use marketplaces or retail partners.
- **Need volume and production stability?** Use wholesale once your product is proven and operations are mature.

3. DTC channels (direct-to-consumer)

DTC means you control the customer journey and capture the most data. It's also where founders can move fastest and test offers cheaply.

DTC channel	Best for	Advantages	Disadvantages / risks
Brand website (Shopify / custom)	Building an asset + premium positioning	Own data, higher AOV, better storytelling	Traffic cost; needs strong product pages + trust
Instagram / TikTok (organic)	Demand creation + community	Free reach, social proof, rapid testing	Slow and inconsistent if your content system is weak
Instagram Shop / TikTok Shop (if available)	Impulse buys	Frictionless checkout	Platform rules + fees; limited data
WhatsApp / DM selling	High intent audiences (Egypt especially)	High conversion, personal trust	Not scalable without SOPs; messy tracking
Pop-up (short-term)	Launches + drops + brand experience	Creates urgency; content + PR	Operational effort; wrong location kills it

DTC readiness checklist

- Clear product page: fit, fabric, sizing, care, photos, video, reviews.
- Fast, reliable fulfillment (and a return/exchange process you can actually execute).
- A predictable content system (weekly output) or a paid acquisition budget + testing plan.
- A pricing strategy that survives ads/returns (margin before scale).

4. Wholesale (B2B) explained

Wholesale means you sell inventory to a business (retailer/wholesaler) at a lower price, and they resell it. It can stabilize production and create scale, but it can also destroy your margin and brand if you enter too early.

Wholesale model	How it works	When it makes sense	Typical risk
Retailer wholesale	Store buys your stock; sells in their shop.	You have strong sellers + consistent quality.	Store discounts your brand.
Distributor	Distributor covers many stores; you sell to distributor.	You need wider geographic reach.	You lose control + pay margin to middleman.
Showroom / agent	They represent you to buyers for commission.	You have a distinct brand + line sheet.	Wrong agent = no orders + time waste.
Consignment	Store pays you only after item sells.	Early exposure, small runs.	Cashflow pain; loss/damage disputes.

Wholesale numbers you must understand

- **Keystone pricing:** many retailers expect ~2× markup (they buy at 50% of retail).
- **Terms:** payment timing matters more than the order size. Net-30 vs upfront changes your cashflow.
- **Returns/chargebacks:** some buyers push risk back on you. Get terms in writing.

5. Physical retail: your store, pop-ups, and partners

Physical channels are expensive, but they can convert better and build brand trust fast. The key is separating **permanent fixed cost** (a store) from **temporary experiments** (pop-ups).

Physical option	Best for	Advantages	Disadvantages
Own store (permanent)	Established brand, stable demand	Brand control + repeat customers	Rent + staff + inventory risk
Pop-up (1–14 days)	Drops, launches, seasonal peaks	High urgency + content + PR	Logistics + permits; location dependent
Shop-in-shop / corner	Testing a mall without full rent	Lower risk vs full store	Still fixed costs; limited control
Retail partner (stockist)	Distribution without rent	Access to foot traffic	Lower margin; control loss

When a store is a good idea

- You already sell consistently online (proof of demand).
- Your brand benefits from touch/fit (denim, tailoring, premium fabrics).
- You have operational discipline: inventory counts, staff scripts, POS tracking.
- Your location math works: traffic + conversion + AOV cover rent and payroll with buffer.

6. Online vs Physical: a practical comparison

Most founders pick channels based on ego (“we need a store”) or fear (“ads are scary”). Use this comparison to pick based on constraints.

Dimension	Online (DTC)	Physical retail
Speed to start	Fast (days/weeks)	Slow (weeks/months)
Fixed costs	Low	High (rent + staff)
Variable costs	Shipping, returns, payment fees	Shrinkage, staff time, utilities
Conversion drivers	Trust, product page, offer, social proof	Try-on, service, instant gratification
Brand building	Strong if content + design are strong	Strong by experience and presence
Data ownership	High (your pixel, CRM)	Medium (depends on POS + capture)
Scale potential	High and flexible	Location-limited unless multi-store
Main failure mode	No traffic or weak conversion	Bad location + cash drain

Rule of thumb (Egypt context)

- Start online + WhatsApp to prove demand, then use **pop-ups** as your bridge to physical.
- A permanent store is a scaling move, not a starting move (unless you have guaranteed foot traffic + capital buffer).

7. Channel strategy by stage

Pick channels based on your stage and bottleneck. Each stage has a different job.

Stage	Your goal	Best channels to focus	Don't do this yet
Pre-launch	Validate product + build audience	Instagram/TikTok + WhatsApp + waitlist	Wholesale, permanent store
Launch / Drop	Convert attention into orders	DTC website + WhatsApp + pop-up (optional)	Too many marketplaces
Post-launch	Improve margin + repeat rate	Website CRO + retention + selective retail partners	Deep discounting to fake growth
Scale	Systemize + expand distribution	Marketplaces + wholesale + retail partners (if brand is stable)	Expanding while ops are chaotic

Bottleneck diagnosis

- **Low views** → content/creative problem (not a “new channel” problem).
- **High views, low clicks** → offer/positioning problem.
- **Clicks, low sales** → product page, sizing, trust, or pricing problem.
- **Sales, no repeat** → product quality/expectation + customer experience problem.

8. Operations that make Place work

Distribution fails because founders underestimate operations. A channel is only as strong as the weakest operational link.

- **Inventory discipline:** clear SKU system, size runs, and weekly stock counts.
- **Fulfillment SOPs:** packing standards, QC checklist, shipping cutoffs, delivery SLAs.
- **Returns/exchanges:** predictable policy + internal process (reverse logistics).
- **Customer support:** response time targets; scripts for sizing, delays, and complaints.
- **Omnichannel:** one inventory truth (avoid overselling), unified pricing rules.

Hidden costs that destroy margin

- Returns rate + exchange shipping.
- Failed deliveries / COD refusal (if you use COD).
- Marketplace commissions + mandatory promos.
- Stockouts on best sellers while slow items sit.
- Pop-up setup: fixtures, staff, transport, packaging, POS.

9. Metrics and KPIs for Place decisions

If you don't measure, you can't choose channels intelligently. Track the minimum set below.

Metric	What it tells you	Healthy direction
Channel contribution margin	True profitability per channel after fees/returns.	Up
Conversion rate (CVR)	Store/site effectiveness.	Up
Average order value (AOV)	Basket size / bundling success.	Up
Return / exchange rate	Sizing/quality expectation match.	Down
Fulfillment time	Operational reliability.	Down
Repeat purchase rate	Product + experience quality.	Up
CAC / MER (if ads)	Acquisition efficiency.	CAC down; MER up

Channel expansion decision (simple)

- Expand only if your current channel has: **stable weekly sales, positive contribution margin, and operations under control.**
- If you can't keep stock for your best sellers, you are not ready for more channels.

10. Channel checklists

Use these as “go/no-go” gates.

10.1 DTC Website checklist

Area	Must have
Product page	Fit photos, close-ups, fabric, sizing chart, care, clear price, shipping/returns, reviews.
Trust	Brand story, contact, WhatsApp button, payment options, delivery ETA, policies.
Conversion	Fast load, clear CTA, bundles, upsells, size guidance, FAQ.
Ops	Real stock levels, order tracking, returns workflow, customer support response time.

10.2 Pop-up checklist (1–14 days)

Area	Must have
Location	Traffic that matches your buyer, not just cheap rent.
Inventory	Best sellers + size depth + clear SKU labeling.
Setup	POS, lighting, mirrors, fitting room plan, packaging.
Staff	Sales script, sizing help, upsell bundles, queue management.
Content	Creator plan: hooks, try-ons, UGC station, before/after.
Measurement	Foot traffic, conversion, AOV, top SKUs, leads captured.

10.3 Wholesale readiness checklist

Area	Must have
Product	Consistent quality + repeatable sizing; proven top SKUs.
Assets	Line sheet, lookbook, wholesale pricing, terms.
Production	Lead times you can hit; MOQ planning; QC process.
Logistics	Packaging, barcodes/SKUs, delivery reliability.
Finance	Cashflow plan for production before payment; clear returns terms.

11. Common mistakes (and how to avoid them)

- **Opening a store too early:** you turn marketing into rent payment.
- **Wholesale before product proof:** you lock low margin pricing on untested items.
- **Relying on marketplaces for demand:** you become a commodity with fees and promos.
- **Too many channels at once:** inventory chaos → stockouts + angry customers.
- **No channel rules:** different prices everywhere → brand trust drops.

Final ruthless rule

- Place is a system. If you can't run the system, the channel will punish you.
- Your job is to pick the **simplest channel** that matches your stage and gives you learning + profit.